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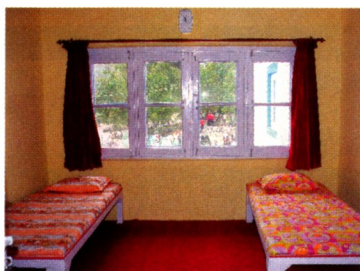
BACK TO LIFE: The new hostel building; the quake-ravaged structure (left)

Staff, General Deepak Kapoor, and India Today Group Editor-in-Chief Aroon Purie flew from Delhi to Tangdhar to formally dedicate the hostel to the community on May 9. The hostel has two floors comprising 32 rooms, including 22 for staying, facilities for wardens, common rooms, computer rooms, a dining hall and kitchen, and bathrooms. "This hostel is a symbol of our association with the people of Tangdhar area," Kapoor said at the inaugural function which was attended by top army and civil officials besides local dignitaries. "We're thankful to CARE TODAY in assisting us build this wonderful facility," he said, pointing out that he had been involved in the project since its inception.

Terming the venture a humble initiative by CARE TODAY, Purie said, "It is heartening to see something wonderful emerge out of a terrible tragedy." Dubbing the project a "symbol of hope", he said the venture would enable children of poor families in border villages get the best facilities for their education and progress. "I am delighted that besides reporting the disaster, we are able to help rebuild people's lives," he said at the function.

Forty children, including seven girls, have been admitted to the hostel. The demand for admission has put the authorities under pressure, with requests for admission coming from as far away as Chowkibal, across the

FRESH CHAPTER: (top to bottom)
The hostel mess, the living quarters and the students' common room



10,500-ft high Sadhna Pass. "The building is built, the infrastructure is in place. The challenge now is to ensure that children from villages in this remote border region gain from the facility, today and in the future," said Ajit Chaudhuri, director of CARE TODAY.

Village elders know what this facility means for their children. Tangdhar used to be one of the prime transit areas in the erstwhile princely state of Jammu and Kashmir for those travelling out of the valley for better and higher education. In those days, the area was considered educationally forward and enjoyed a status next only to that of Muzaffarabad in this part of the state. But now it is one of the remotest parts on the Indian side of Kashmir. People here still place a great premium on quality education which has eluded them ever since the Partition in 1947 pushed them to the margins. One reason perhaps why this modern hostel facility is now being called the 'Crown of Tangdhar'.

CARE TODAY would like to thank all the readers and viewers of India Today Group's publications and channels who made this initiative possible in the aftermath of the Kashmir earthquake. A sum of Rs 62.13 lakh was received as contributions to the Comfort Kashmir Fund and grants of Rs 56.52 lakh have been made so far. The fund now stands closed for further contributions.

by Aijaz Hussain in Tangdhar